

Measurements and shapes

Teaching guide

Describe size with an appropriate unit and pattern.

Understand the distinction

Use an adjective after the measurement: The table is two meters long. Use a noun with of: a length of two meters. In a compound adjective before a noun, the unit is singular: a two-meter table.

Choose the dimension you mean: long for length, wide for width, high or tall for height, and deep for depth. Tall is common for people and upright objects. Use square, round, or rectangular for shape. Always include the unit when a number alone is unclear.

Compare the patterns

AFTER THE NOUN

The cable is three meters long.

The measurement describes the cable.

BEFORE THE NOUN

It is a three-meter cable.

The unit stays singular in this compound adjective.

SHAPE

The table is rectangular.

Rectangular describes shape, not size.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Correct this: a five-meters cable

2. Complete: The pool is two meters ____ . (depth / deep)

3. What information is missing from The desk is 120 wide?

Use it in your own life

Describe an object using a dimension, a unit, and a shape.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. a five-meter cable

Use the singular unit in a compound adjective.

2. deep

An adjective follows this measurement.

3. The unit, such as centimeters.

The number needs a unit to be useful.

One possible response

My desk is 120 centimeters wide. Its top is rectangular.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-22.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Ask learners to explain the differences between the comparison examples before reading the rules. Use their answers to identify the point that needs attention.

2. Explain and check (4 minutes)

Read the short explanation together. Keep its qualifications: a common pattern is not necessarily a rule for every context. Ask learners to give a counterexample where the lesson mentions an exception.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Describe an object using a dimension, a unit, and a shape.

Have learners work alone, then compare with a partner. Ask the partner to restate the intended meaning before suggesting a correction.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Use the answer explanations to review the three checks. Accept natural alternatives that preserve the intended meaning. Ask each learner to revise one sentence and identify the change.

Extension

Change the person, time, place, or purpose in a comparison example. Ask whether the original pattern still fits and why. Revisit one example in the next lesson.

Feedback criteria

Meaning: the message is understandable. Form: the target pattern fits the context. Transfer: the learner can use it in a fresh example. This short activity is not a proficiency certification.